CSC MASTER'S GUIDE · 3 OF 6

Objectives and Career Plans

Award objectives, the five years after the award and the long-term vision, written so that each stage visibly enables the next.

750	3	2	Free
WORDS ACROSS 3 ANSWERS	TIME HORIZONS	WORKED EXAMPLES	TO READ & DOWNLOAD

ABOUT THE EXAMPLES.

All names, institutions, universities, academics, programmes and statistics below are anonymised and reinvented versions of successful Commonwealth Master's applications, changed to show technique. Yours must be real.

THE LIVE QUESTIONS (2027/28).

Three separate boxes, each up to 250 words.

- **OBJECTIVES DURING THE AWARD.**

  What do you intend to study or research? What is your networking objective? What are your personal growth objectives? How do these objectives link back to the impact you want to create?
- **CAREER PLANS IN THE FIVE YEARS FOLLOWING THE AWARD.**

  Briefly explain your immediate objective. Explain your mid-term goal. Connect it briefly with your long-term goal.
- **LONG-TERM CAREER PLANS.**

  Where will your career have taken you, and what will exist because of it?

WHAT IS BEING SCORED.

The CSC's study-plan indicators reward a clear statement of what you want to learn and how it connects to your objectives. Its development-impact indicators reward the way and extent to which you will apply new skills, a national priority or capacity shortage, and the extent of benefit. These three answers carry that evidence in time.

01 SECTION 1

Part one: three horizons, three jobs

Word plan.

ANSWER	SPLIT AT 250 WORDS
Objectives	Capability gap 20, study 90, networking 60, personal growth 40, link to impact 40
Five-year plan	Immediate (years one to two) 80, mid-term (years three to five) 110, link to long term 60
Long-term plan	Vision 40, institution or system 110, route and partners 50, indicators 50

These three answers are not Development Impact Part 3. Part 3 describes what will change in the world over the next ten years. These answers describe what **you** will do, and what you will become able to do, at each stage. The same plan appears in both, but from different sides: one is the change, the other is the career that produces it. Keep the numbers identical, and do not copy the sentences.

ANSWER	HORIZON	THE JOB IT DOES
Objectives	The award year	Show what the year gives you that you cannot get at home
Five-year plan	Years one to five after the award	Show a credible, measurable first stage with named partners
Long-term plan	Roughly years five to fifteen	Show the institution or system you will have built

Read them as one sequence. The award year builds capabilities. The first five years use them in a pilot, then a scale-up. The long term turns that into something that outlives your own involvement. Each stage must visibly enable the next.

02 SECTION 2

Part two: four rules that decide these answers

Rule one: capabilities, not job titles

"I will become Director of Policy within five years" is unfalsifiable, and titles are awarded by other people for reasons you do not control. What the panel can assess is whether each capability plausibly follows from the one before.

TITLE THINKING	CAPABILITY THINKING
"I will be a senior adviser."	"I will build the evaluation function the Commission currently outsources."
"I will run a large NGO."	"I will manage a consortium of recyclers and manufacturers, not a single pilot."
"I will be a professor."	"I will lead the research hub that produces the country's first battery recovery data."

Rule two: every goal needs a road

For every goal, the next clause should answer "through what?": which institution, which partner, which rule, which budget. A destination without a road is a wish.

Rule three: show altitude increasing

In the first five years you move from individual contribution to institutional influence: pilots, partnerships, advisory roles, funding. In the long term you affect the system: the standard, the framework, the platform, the research centre. If both answers sit at the same level, the plan is flat. A plan in which you are still doing pilots after fifteen years is as weak as one in which you run a ministry after five.

Rule four: name the door

"I will work for an international organisation" tells the panel you have not looked. Name the think-tank, ministry directorate, commission, regulator or programme you will join, and name the partners you will work with. At least one name should recur from Development Impact Part 2.

Part three: objectives during the award, beat by beat (250 words)

The capability gap, around 20 words

Open with what you cannot currently do. "I cannot yet test whether a policy works, cost it, or bring a reluctant administration to adopt it." This turns the whole answer into a plan to close a gap and makes the study feel necessary.

What you will study, around 90 words

The CSC's indicator is a clear statement of what you want to learn and how it connects to your objectives. The most convincing way to give it is a **module-to-objective map**: each module gives you a skill, and each skill has a use at home.

MODULE OR ACTIVITY	THE SKILL	THE USE AT HOME
Econometric Methods for Development	Designing a matched comparison	Credible evidence for the Commission that the model works
Public Sector Reform, with Dr Lindqvist	Understanding why institutions resist	A plan for winning over kiln-owning local officials
Life Cycle Assessment	Measuring what is lost in informal dismantling	The baseline for the CEEP policy model
Dissertation	Building the model	The first deliverable of the pilot

Do not list every module. Choose three or four, name them exactly as in the current handbook, and say what each one gives you. **Merely listing the options on a Master's course is not enough.**

Networking, around 60 words

A networking objective is a named plan, not a wish to "meet people". Name the institutions, the events and the kind of person you want to meet, and say what you will do with the contacts.

> ***Weak:*** *"I will build a strong network of professionals."*
> ***Strong:*** *"I will join the Westmoor Battery Research Hub, meet UK recyclers through client projects, and organise two sessions for Commonwealth scholars working on waste, building on conferences I have run in two countries."*

Include a plan that reaches the Commonwealth network. The CSC is a Commonwealth programme, and a networking objective that includes it fits the scheme.

Personal growth, around 40 words

Name one or two skills that matter for the work at home and that the year can develop: arguing from evidence, leading ethical fieldwork, writing for a sceptical official, handling children's data. A personal growth objective that is about being "more confident" is not enough. One that is about a skill you will need on day one is.

The link to impact, around 40 words

Close by showing each objective feeds a specific task at home. "The analysis feeds the CEEP policy model, the tracking research feeds the pilot, and the network supplies the recyclers the pilot needs." This is the sentence that turns a study plan into a development case.

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04 SECTION 4

Part four: five-year career plan, beat by beat (250 words)

Immediate objective, years one to two, around 80 words

Where you start, with whom, and what you will deliver. Name the institution, the role and a first target.

> *"After graduating I will join CEEP and run ReCircle pilots in three recycling clusters, beginning with Ashbury Yard. By 2030 the target is 2,400 tonnes of battery waste collected formally and 8,000 workers registered, with 4,000 registered in the first year."*

Keep it consistent with Development Impact Part 2. The first year in Part 2 should match the immediate objective here, and the first phase in Part 3 should match the targets. Say it in different words, with the same numbers.

Mid-term goal, years three to five, around 110 words

This is the scale-up and the first institutional influence. Name the partners, the places and the policy work. This is also where you bring in the policy rule or national programme that your work plugs into.

> *"In years three to five I will scale to 12 cities with partners such as the National Recyclers' Association, Kesra Metals and the vehicle maker Sunrise Mobility, and advise the Ministry of Industry on standards for second-life batteries. With the Ministry of Environment I will help make Extended Producer Responsibility, the rule that makes manufacturers pay for recycling their products, inclusive of informal workers."*

Aim for influence, not only delivery. Advisory roles, standards, funding bids and publications show that your work is moving from a pilot to an institutional contribution.

Link to the long term, around 60 words

One or two sentences that connect the five-year work to what comes next. It should show that the evidence, partners and operating record from the first stage are what make the long-term plan possible. "The pilots give me the operating record, the partners and the data to build the platform described in my long-term plan."

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05 SECTION 5

Part five: long-term plan, beat by beat (250 words)

The vision, around 40 words

One sentence about what your country or sector will look like, dated. "By 2043 I want my country to move from importing battery metals to recovering most of what its vehicles use, with the workers who do the work inside the system."

The institution or system, around 110 words

The thing you will have built. The strongest long-term visions describe something that keeps producing value after you move on: a research centre, a training system, a policy mechanism, a platform, an accreditation route, a data infrastructure. "I want to become a senior manager" is a destination for you. "I want to build the thing that outlives my post" is a destination for your sector.

Describe how it works in plain language, step by step, so a non-specialist can picture it.

> *"Certified workers collect retired batteries from households, garages and fleets and deposit them at neighbourhood hubs. Licensed recyclers recover the metals, and small manufacturers and vehicle makers buy them back or reuse batteries in second-life*

> *applications. Every battery carries a digital passport, so that collection, processing and reuse can be traced."*

Name it once. Give the flagship one proper name and use it consistently. Do not introduce three new programmes in the long-term answer.

Route and partners, around 50 words

How it will be financed and who will carry it. Off-take agreements, training institutes, ministries, donors, public-private models. A long-term vision without a financing route is a wish.

Indicators, around 50 words

Dated, checkable and at the level of the system. "By 2043 I aim for 120,000 certified workers and 35 per cent of the country's battery materials recovered domestically." Then say how you will publish and check it.

Use only indicators your work really produces. People trained, institutions engaged, partnerships established, research published, coverage extended, costs reduced. Never invent one.

06 SECTION 6

Part six: two full sample sets

Bracketed labels show structure. Do not include them. All names are invented.

Sample set one, battery circularity

Sample one, Objectives during the award

> *I cannot currently build three capabilities at home: measuring what a battery contains and where it goes, designing policy that informal workers can enter, and tracking batteries through a supply chain. The year at Westmoor University is designed to close those gaps. Life Cycle Assessment and Material Flow Analysis will let me quantify how much metal is lost in informal dismantling. Systems Dynamics and Professor Ines Calder's elective on circular-economy policy will teach me to simulate how rule changes affect workers, recyclers and producers. My dissertation, "Registering the Informal: Policy Pathways for Battery Circularity", will apply both to Port Marrow. At the Westmoor Circular Economy Centre I will assist Dr*

> *Tomas Wray's research on using sensors to track batteries, the basis of the battery passport I intend to pilot.*
> *For networking, I will use client projects and guest lectures to meet UK recyclers and battery developers, join the Westmoor Battery Research Hub, and visit practitioner networks across the south of England. I will organise two knowledge-exchange sessions between UK practitioners and Commonwealth scholars working on waste, building on conferences I have run in two countries.*
> *For personal growth, I want to learn to defend a policy recommendation with evidence rather than conviction, and to lead field research ethically with workers who have good reason to distrust outsiders.*
> *Each objective feeds a task at home. The analysis feeds the CEEP policy model, the tracking research feeds the pilot, and the network supplies the recyclers and manufacturers the pilot needs.*

Sample one, Five-year career plan

> *After graduating I will join the Centre for Energy and Environment Policy (CEEP) and run ReCircle, a battery circularity programme, in three recycling clusters, beginning with Ashbury Yard. By 2030 the target is 2,400 tonnes of battery waste collected formally and 8,000 workers registered, with 4,000 registered in the first year.*
> *In years three to five I will begin scaling to 12 cities with partners such as the National Recyclers' Association, the recycler Kesra Metals and the vehicle maker Sunrise Mobility, working towards 9,000 tonnes a year. Alongside delivery I will advise the Ministry of Industry on standards for second-life batteries, so that used batteries can be reused safely and certified. With the Ministry of Environment I will help make Extended Producer Responsibility, the rule that makes manufacturers pay for recycling their products, inclusive of informal workers, using the policy-simulation methods and techno-economic modelling I will learn at Westmoor University. I will publish the pilot results, including what did not work, so that policy is built on evidence and not on assumptions.*
> *The pilots give me what I cannot get from study alone: an operating record, a set of partners who trust the model, and data on what recovery really costs. That is the foundation for the independent digital platform in my long-term plan, which will turn the pilots into a permanent national system.*

Sample one, Long-term career plan

> *By 2043 I want my country to move from importing battery metals to recovering most of what its vehicles use, with the workers who do the work inside the system.*

> *To get there, ReCircle will become an independent digital platform that runs the whole battery loop. Certified workers collect retired batteries from households, garages and fleets and deposit them at neighbourhood hubs. Licensed recyclers recover the metals, and small manufacturers and vehicle makers buy them back or reuse batteries in second-life applications, under the Battery Waste Management Rules. Every battery carries a digital passport, so that collection, processing and reuse can be traced from first sale to final recovery.*
> *I will secure off-take agreements with vehicle makers and recyclers so that the loop is financed by the materials it recovers, and work with training institutes to certify workers in safe handling. The ministries I advised in the first five years will be the policy home for the platform, and the pilots will be its operating record.*
> *By 2043 I aim for 120,000 certified workers and 35 per cent of the country's battery materials recovered domestically, with recovery rates above 92 per cent for lithium, cobalt and nickel. I will publish annual figures on workers certified, tonnes collected and metal recovered, so the platform's success can be checked, and so other countries facing the same problem can adapt the method.*

Sample set two, child labour

Sample two, Objectives during the award

> *I cannot yet test whether a policy works, cost it, or bring a reluctant administration to adopt it. The year at Halden University is designed to close those three gaps.*
> *In Econometric Methods for Development I will learn to design a matched comparison for my savings-linked attendance model, so that results are credible to a sceptical Commission. In Public Sector Reform I will study why institutions resist change, drawing on Dr Maya Lindqvist's work on incentives in local government, which describes the kiln-owner problem I face. My dissertation will build the funding model: an adaptive rule that links savings-group loan tranches to school attendance and local risk data, using GIS mapping. I also want to learn how to handle children's data ethically and legally.*
> *For networking, I will join Halden's Policy Lab, attend its sessions with practitioners from international organisations, and use the Commonwealth Scholars' regional network to organise two sessions on rural child welfare with scholars from South Asia and Africa. I want a mentor who has run a policy pilot in a comparable setting.*
> *For personal growth, I want to move from advocacy to analysis: writing a policy brief that a sceptical official will read, and presenting evidence to people who disagree with me. Together these give me the method, the evidence and the contacts to start work at the Provincial Child Protection Commission within a year of returning.*

Sample two, Five-year career plan

> *After returning in 2028 I will join the Provincial Child Protection Commission as a policy analyst and spend two years building the evidence and the pilot. In year one I will survey 60 villages in Dunmore District and map the kiln hamlets. In year two I will launch ClassFirst, the pilot that links the dividends of women's savings groups to school attendance, in 12 high-risk hamlets with the Dunmore Women's Savings Federation.*
> *In years three to five I will extend ClassFirst across Dunmore with the Commission, aiming for a measurable fall in child labour and a rise in attendance by year five. I will fund the work through the microgrant that proved the model's feasibility and through applications to research funders, and I will publish the results, including failures, to invite scrutiny. I will use my UK network to find research partners and to test the funding algorithm designed in my dissertation. Alongside delivery I will work with the Provincial Planning Department to put community reporting of child labour into the district's official monitoring, so that enforcement no longer depends on inspectors who rarely visit.*
> *By year five the evidence will be strong enough to propose provincial adoption. That is the step that connects this plan to my long-term goal: turning a district model into provincial policy, and then into a research and monitoring institution that outlasts me.*

Sample two, Long-term career plan

> *Over the next decade I want to turn a district model into a permanent provincial system that keeps children in school and gives every community the means to protect them.*
> *By 2036 I aim to bring Dunmore's child labour rate below 1 per cent and to have ClassFirst adopted by the Commission as provincial guidance. I will then build the Tarn Child Welfare Data Hub: an open data and research centre, financed through a public-private partnership, that maps child labour risk by hamlet, tracks the results of interventions, and publishes findings that officials, donors and communities can use. It will act as a public check as well as a research centre, because it will report on whether districts are meeting their targets.*
> *To make this last, I will embed the Data Hub in the Provincial Planning Department's monitoring system, and work with teacher-training colleges to build awareness of child labour into the curriculum, so that new teachers know how to identify and report risk. I will build research partnerships to compare Tarn with other provinces and with neighbouring countries, learning what keeps the most vulnerable children in school.*
> *I will measure success by changes in the share of working children, school completion and dropout ratios, the number of women organised into savings groups and their dividends, and the number of districts reporting through the Data Hub. I will publish annual figures so that the model can be tested, criticised and replicated.*

What both sets do. They open on the capability gap and map modules to uses. They name partners who recur from Development Impact. They state the numbers from Part 3 in different words. They move from delivery to influence in the five-year plan, and from a pilot to a permanent institution in the long-term plan. They name a flagship once and use it consistently. They end with indicators someone else could check.

07 SECTION 7

Part seven: dos and don'ts

Do

- Open the objectives with a capability gap
- Map each module to a skill and a use at home
- Name the institutions, events and people in your networking plan
- Tie personal growth to a skill you need on day one
- Name the institution you will join and the partners you will work with
- Keep your numbers identical to Development Impact
- Move from delivery in years one to two to influence in years three to five
- Describe the long-term system in plain steps
- Give the flagship one name
- Date the long-term indicators and say how they will be checked

Don't

- Promise a job title on a timetable
- List every module on the course
- Say you will "build a strong network"
- Repeat Development Impact Part 3 in different words
- Introduce several new programmes in the long-term answer
- Aim so low that a decade produces no growth in influence
- Aim so high that the plan needs resources you will never have
- Use "paradigm shift" or "revolutionise"

- Invent an indicator

08 SECTION 8

Part eight: common mistakes, and the fix

MISTAKE	WHY IT COSTS MARKS	THE FIX
Objectives that list modules	The link to your objectives is missing	Map each module to a skill and a use at home
"I will build a strong network."	Unverifiable and generic	Name the institutions, events and what you will do with them
Personal growth is "more confidence"	Not tied to the work	Name a skill you will use on day one
Five-year plan is a job title	Unfalsifiable	Describe the capability, the institution and the target
Five-year numbers differ from Development Impact	The plan looks inconsistent	Keep identical numbers and dates
No named partners	The route is a guess	Name three, including one that recurs
Long term is a senior post	A destination for you, not your sector	Describe what you will build that outlives your post
Three new programmes in the long term	A brochure	Name one flagship and carry it through
Long term with no date	Unbounded ambition reads as unserious	Attach a year and a metric to that year
Both horizons at the same altitude	The plan is flat	Show delivery, then influence, then system
No financing route	A wish	Name how the system will be paid for

MISTAKE	WHY IT COSTS MARKS	THE FIX
No link between the three answers	Reads as three separate plans	End each by pointing to the next

09 SECTION 9

Part nine: checklists

While drafting

- The capability gap stated at the start of the objectives
- Three or four modules mapped to skills and uses
- A named networking plan that includes the Commonwealth network
- A personal growth objective tied to the work at home
- The institution, role and first target in the five-year plan
- Numbers identical to Development Impact
- Named partners, including one that recurs
- Delivery in years one to two, influence in years three to five
- A long-term system described in plain steps and given one name
- A financing route and dated indicators

Before submitting

- All sub-questions in each box answered
- The five-year plan connects explicitly to the long-term plan
- No repetition of Development Impact sentences
- The long-term altitude is higher than the five-year altitude
- Every organisation named correctly and spelled consistently
- Nothing contradicts the employment entries or the personal statement
- Within each word limit shown in the live form
- I could defend every target, date and partner at a nominator's interview

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